VELLORE INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY

Bhopal Campus

PROJECT REPORT

Digital Literacy Awareness

A Student-Led Initiative for Responsible Digital Citizenship

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1. Introduction

In an increasingly connected world, digital literacy has become as fundamental as reading and writing. This project, titled Digital Literacy Awareness, was undertaken as part of the academic curriculum at VIT Bhopal University. It aims to educate fellow students about responsible, safe, and effective use of digital technologies.

The project covers four core areas: understanding what digital literacy means, safe internet practices, responsible social media use, and awareness of online financial frauds — particularly UPI-related scams prevalent in India.

2. Objectives

- To define digital literacy and its relevance to college students in 2026.
- To raise awareness about cyber threats, phishing, and safe browsing habits.
- To educate peers on responsible social media behaviour and digital etiquette.
- To highlight common UPI and online payment frauds and how to avoid them.
- To demonstrate learning through a Google Form quiz, platform profiles, and coding activity.

3. What is Digital Awareness?

Digital awareness, as explored in this project, is the understanding of how digital tools, platforms, and information ecosystems function — and how to navigate them safely and responsibly. It goes beyond simply knowing how to operate a device.

3.1 Definition of Digital Literacy

Digital literacy is defined as the ability to use digital technologies effectively, responsibly, and safely. This encompasses searching and critically evaluating online information, communicating through digital channels with proper etiquette, and recognising and defending against cyber threats.

3.2 The Four Core Pillars

Pillar	Description
Device Proficiency	Confidently operating computers, smartphones, and software to accomplish real-world tasks.
Information Evaluation	Searching, assessing, and critically analysing the reliability of online information.
Digital Communication	Communicating through emails, social media, and platforms with clarity and proper etiquette.
Cyber Safety	Recognising threats, avoiding scams, and using strong, unique passwords to stay secure.

4. Safe Internet Practices

One of the central themes of this project is promoting safe internet habits. The following practices were compiled and shared with students as part of the awareness campaign:

Key Online Safety Habits

✓ Create strong, unique passwords using a mix of letters, numbers, and symbols.
✓ Enable Two-Factor Authentication (2FA) on all important accounts.
✓ Avoid logging into banking apps on public Wi-Fi networks.
✓ Never click on suspicious links received via SMS, email, or WhatsApp.
✓ Keep all apps and devices regularly updated for security patches.
✓ Never share your OTP, PIN, or password with anyone — not even bank officials.
✓ Always verify the recipient name before approving UPI payment requests.
✓ Only download apps from official stores: Google Play Store or Apple App Store.
✓ Log out completely after using shared or public computers.
✓ Scan QR codes only from verified, trusted sources.

Students were also informed about the emergency reporting channel: the National Cyber Crime Portal (cybercrime.gov.in) and the Cyber Crime Helpline 1930, active across India.

5. Responsible Social Media Use

College students are among the most active users of social media platforms. This section of the project highlighted five key principles for responsible usage:

5.1 Think Before You Post

Students were encouraged to consider how their posts might be viewed by professors, future employers, or family before publishing. Emotional or reactive posts often lead to long-term reputational damage, as the internet retains information indefinitely.

5.2 Protect Personal Information

Sharing home addresses, daily routines, financial details, or real-time locations on public platforms exposes users to risk. Privacy settings should be reviewed regularly, and suspicious follow requests should be blocked without hesitation.

5.3 Be Kind and Responsible Online

Online behaviour carries real-world consequences. Students were reminded to interact online with the same respect and decency they would show in person, and to avoid participating in public drama or targeted harassment.

5.4 Fact-Check Before Sharing

The rapid spread of misinformation on platforms makes it essential to verify claims before sharing them. A quick search before re-sharing a news story or health claim can prevent the spread of false information and protect personal credibility.

5.5 Protect Time and Mental Health

Social media is engineered to maximise engagement and can lead to excessive screen time and negative self-comparison. Students were advised to set daily usage limits, take regular breaks, and unfollow accounts that consistently cause distress.

6. UPI and Online Payment Fraud Awareness

With the widespread adoption of digital payment platforms such as Google Pay, PhonePe, and Paytm in India, financial fraud has become a major concern. This project dedicated a focused section to educating students about the most common fraud types and how to avoid them.

6.1 QR Code and Fake Payment Request Scams

A common misconception is that scanning a QR code is a way to receive money. In reality, doing so authorises a payment going out of the account. Fraudsters exploit this misunderstanding by sending fake QR codes to unsuspecting users.

6.2 Impersonation and OTP Fraud

Scammers impersonate bank officials or customer support agents to pressure users into sharing OTPs, UPI PINs, or debit card details. No legitimate bank employee will ever request this information. Sharing it results in immediate unauthorised fund transfers.

6.3 Fake Websites and Malicious Links

Cybercriminals create convincing replicas of official banking websites to harvest login credentials. A single click on a fraudulent link or entering details on a spoofed site can compromise an account entirely.

6.4 Preventive Measures

- Never share OTP or UPI PIN with anyone under any circumstances.
- Verify all payment requests before approving them — confirm the recipient's name.
- Enable transaction alerts so any unauthorised activity is detected immediately.
- Avoid clicking on unsolicited payment links sent via SMS or WhatsApp.
- If scammed, call Cyber Crime Helpline 1930 immediately and report to the bank.

7. Project Activities and Evidence

This project was not limited to research and documentation. Several hands-on activities were undertaken to demonstrate digital literacy in practice:

7.1 Digital Literacy Awareness Quiz

A Google Form quiz titled 'Digital Literacy Awareness Quiz' was designed and published, collecting responses from peers. The quiz covered topics including the definition of digital literacy, safe internet habits, and UPI fraud awareness. Three responses were collected, with scores of 30/30, 20/30, and 30/30.

7.2 Professional Profiles

As evidence of digital proficiency and professional digital presence, the following profiles were created and maintained:

- LinkedIn profile — Sarthak Jena, VIT Bhopal, showcasing academic identity and professional intent.

- GitHub profile — username: sarthak25bai10247-eng, featuring the chem-project (CSS) repository and an AI-ML-PROJECT with recent commits in March 2026.
- CodeChef profile — username: sarthakjena, registered for competitive programming contests.

7.3 Coding Activity

A programming challenge on CodeChef was completed: 'Search an Element in an Array' (Difficulty: 600) using Python3. The solution produced a correct output (YES) with a subtask score of 16%, demonstrating the application of programming skills as a component of digital literacy.

7.4 Professional Email Writing

Two formal emails were drafted as part of the project: an internship application to Citadel demonstrating professional email etiquette, and an extension request letter addressed to the concerned professor. Both followed the email etiquette guidelines outlined in the Digital Awareness presentation — clear subject lines, formal tone, proper greetings, and polite closings.

8. Email Etiquette · Best Practices

Professional email communication was identified as a key component of digital literacy for college students. The following guidelines were presented:

Good Practice	Why It Matters
Use a clear, specific subject line	Helps the reader understand the email's purpose immediately
Open with 'Dear' or 'Hello'	Sets a respectful and professional tone
Write concisely in formal/semi-formal tone	Avoids confusion and maintains professionalism
Check grammar and spelling before sending	Demonstrates care and attention to detail
Never write in ALL CAPS	ALL CAPS reads as shouting and is considered rude
Close with 'Thank you' or 'Regards'	Leaves a positive final impression

9. Conclusion

Digital literacy is no longer optional — it is a foundational life skill. Through this project, a comprehensive effort was made to understand, document, and actively demonstrate awareness across all key domains: safe internet use, responsible social media behaviour, protection from financial fraud, professional digital communication, and technical skill building through programming.

The activities undertaken — from creating a digital quiz and professional online profiles, to writing formal emails and solving coding problems — reflect a holistic approach to digital education. The insights gained through this project will contribute to more informed, safer, and more responsible digital habits not just personally, but also for peers who engaged with the awareness materials.

As digital citizens, the responsibility to stay informed, stay safe, and help others do the same is continuous. This project is a step in that direction.

References

- Digital Education Series 2026 — What is Digital Awareness (Project Presentation)
- Stay Safe Online Checklist — Internal Project Document
- UPI and Online Payment Frauds: 5 Big Points — Internal Project Document
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- National Cyber Crime Portal: https://cybercrime.gov.in
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